Life on Death Row: A Monologue

By Walter A. Davis

INTRODUCTION

There are over 600 inmates currently on death row in San Quentin. He's been on death row in San Quentin for the past 15 years. His appeal of the death sentence is now at the Federal level. For that reason I have been advised by attorneys not to use his name and to take other steps to disguise his identity. Within the terms of that restriction what follows is a factually complete account.. Life on Death Row by Walter A. Davis

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I fell off the edge of the world. That's what it felt like, the moment the bars clanged shut. My life over. Nothing now but waiting, without hope, for something that'll come someday, it doesn't matter when, because time is nothing now but this wall in front of me. I see myself under water looking up at Mother's face all twisted, her hands like claws, forcing me down, my eyes pleading, dying- then breaking the surface gasping in a shriek toward air.

There'd be this pop, right in the pit of the stomach and I'd feel all the air go out of me. As if life is breath like Homer says, and mine had gone leaving nothing but the struggle to hide the panic building inside me Because I could see it now -- flashing in front of me-a blanket pressed down over my face, my mother's hands holding me down under the water, my eyes looking up at her, pleading, the whole thing whirling around inside me--until there was nothing but rage, blind rage, to explode out of myself-- as if bringing my fist down upon the world was the only way I could breathe.

That's what they tried to give me. A way to breathe. Mother, Father, Regina-I loved them so, the way they came forth to plead for my life at the trial. They let themselves be known-utterly. All the family secrets. Like they were offering their lives to me so that I could try to piece it all together here. Only like the way it is in a dream-a dream in which

you walk through yourself becoming the thing you behold. Mother weeping all day, every day tied up down in that basement, the rats scurrying across her toes; my father waiting in that shack, trembling, the long processional of men like it was all one day, a summer afternoon, just a little boy but holding his jaw out stiff the way it always got just before he'd start hitting my mother; Regina holding her jaw the same way, refusing to cry, telling the Court what father forced her to do-- what my mother's father did to her-- what I did to that poor little girl, fucking her that way then forcing her head down into the bathtub.

I could see us now, the family, like branches of a poison tree, a tree that could only grow downward, clawing its way into the earth, latching onto whatever it could take hold of to root itself deeper, water itself with our tears, reach out and claw like Mother's fingernails, twine round itself like tendrils choking off anything that could grow upward and break free, dragging everything back down into the one knot at the center. Only now when I woke sobbing it was my mother I heard crying, not me; my father that time I heard him in the kitchen when he thought no one was home, Sis huddling in the corner of the closet when we hid from Momma, whimpering like that but saying "no, no don't you touch me" her face like granite locked in its impenetrable stare.

And I felt it all rush back on me. Everything rushes away but the rage, rage raging in me, in my fists hitting at her, my hands tightening around her throat forcing her down--, so I get to see it in her face for a change-- fear, panic, terror-- the full weight of my body over her pressing down on her wind-pipe, cursing and crying (he emits a terrifying sound) -- only it was too late: there was nothing but her eyes staring at me with that look that came into them right before the end, staring at me like that forever.

I'd put it all together, sitting alone in my cell, and what I knew drove me back out into the hall again, only not like before but now like a dead man walking, shuffling my feet along the floor, the same ten steps one way and then back, eyes fixed on the floor, the arms hanging

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limp, the shoulders stooped like an old man's and what must have been on my face the look of a corpse because everyone stayed clear of me. Everyone except Reverend John. He was from one of Colson's prison ministries and would walk freely among us every day, taking men aside, one by one, whispering to them, opening the book and pointing at it with his insistent finger.

And I guess he knew right away I was one of the ones who'd read the parts in red, over and over, long into the night when the only light left was from the moon, and feel the tidal pull of a compassion so inconceivable that soon I couldn't wait to tell him "yes yes I accept Jesus Christ as my Lord and Savior," weeping and saying it over and over while he held me in the thick embrace of his bear-like arms. And I tried, tried to hold onto Jesus later when I felt him slipping away, no matter how hard I tried to feel his love, tried to hold onto the Reverend too even after I saw that it was all about power for him. He wasn't interested in the questions I was asking now, only in what came later when the beckoning of his sad eyes told me it was time to confess again and sob how thankful I was to him and Jesus for forgiving me, again and again. No, goddammit! I couldn't forgive myself and didn't want to. I'd done the most terrible thing a human being can do. 'Forgive yourself," he said 'even as your heavenly Father forgives you.' Only that doesn't bring back a life. The dead are the only ones who have a right to forgive-and they can't. Their eyes say something else. That death is a horror in which there's no comfort or forgiveness. Only nothingness, pitiless and final--and as your life slips from you the last thing you see is that nothingness, triumphing over every hope and illusion. Besides, the afterlife and the great banquet of forgiveness. It undoes everything. As if all the evil and suffering we do doesn't matter finally. Life's a shell game to amuse something vindictive in us that wants to call itself God.

It got to where all I could do was lay in my cell, balled up in a fetal position, trembling and crying like a baby. So I did it-the one thing you can never do here. I dropped a kite. On

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myself. I'm sorry, a kite, that's what we call it when you slip a note to a guard ratting on somebody. "Save me. He's everywhere now, his dreadlocks like snakes with eyes at the end-eyes like fangs."

They took me to the white room. That's when it really got bad. When I was safe. After they strapped me down on a bed like I asked them to-and I was free, free to rave. I didn't need him anymore. It was all back inside me, but torn loose from all the ways I'd tried to contain it. I could feel it, something ravenous, scooping out chunks of my heart, devouring them: "No" I screamed when they told me they were going to medicate me. "No you can't, not without my permission. I know my rights, even here." Somehow in my raving I knew that this is what had to happen. What I had to go into wherever it took me. The only thing I had to hold onto-my madness. The only thing left that was mine. Mine--even when they put me down in the hole.

That's where it happened, what I'd always sought, deservedEverything drifted away-even the images. I was left with only the one thing. *Emotion.* That's what we are. All we are. Something happens and an emotion is formed. Later something triggers it and it returns-in all its fury. Then it's like what Spinoza said-an emotion can only be replaced by another emotion and the strongest always wins. Hate, fear, love, rage-each the pure product of pure and brutal experiences-warring with each other. Emotion-the thing that tears us apart. And so we try to blow it out into the world. Inflict it on someone else to get some relief. But it always returns to its source. Life nothing but the process of being blown with restless violence from one emotion to another. But always in the end rage, only rage

Let it come, I said, feeling the sweat of it pouring over me rocking myself back and forth in it making my body a cradle for it. For rage so pure it'd consume me, rage raging in me until it burst into remorse-- remorse becoming love-- a terrible love, ripping me apartThen again nothing but the panic of feeling myself-what you'd call my soul-dying within. Then

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reborn, reborn in rage. I felt it claw at me: *not I it,* I said like that play of Beckett's, only I knew it was I and I felt myself vanish into it until there was nothing but one emotion after another searing my flesh. Time went away and space. The room went away. I was utterly alone, with nothing left between me and what I was.

Most of the time it felt like I'd never come back. That rage would claim me so complete and entire that I'd run and dash my brains out against the padded wall. Or that I'd dissolve in a love that was nothing but pity, pity for a loss so deep that one morning they'd find me gone in a weeping that could never end. Or that the panic would seize me"*yes that's how it'll end crying out against myself for the Meds, begging for them, pleading with them please please I'll do anything just take the pain away.*" Or fear, the worst fear, that I'd become my deed-but without remorse-my deed and nothing but a monster raving kill kill kill, living only for horror, wanting it, more of it, unable to get enough of it, hurt and hatred and revenge.

I felt each emotion blow down white hot all over me. Burning itself up in me. Renewing itself through me. And in the brief interim, when the whole thing would pause and turn on itself like a ferris wheel about to run backwards-Dread-- the cold sweat of dread all over me, knowing this might never end yet knowing I had to sustain it because otherwise I was truly lost. *Do it to yourself,* I cried. Be it, rage, hate, terror, despair. Assault yourself with yourself. Make each emotion a spike driven through the brain straight into the heart. *That's the only way,* I cried, and in that cry I became a young girl in Nepal sold into prostitution, raped and beaten by two men; a woman in New York bleeding to death in an alley 10 feet from home, the neighbors gawking through closed windows; then little girls, dozens of them, sexually abused children crying out of me for it to "stop." Stop!" And that's when it began, what had to happen, though I had no way to know it then, all the emotions bleeding into one another, out of their clash refining themselves into something

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else that I no longer felt would crush or swallow me but out of which something new might come to be.

I lay there like a corpse feeling the whole process moving across me the way a rat down here sometimes crawls across your chest in the night, slow and tentative, almost delicate, like it was your companion and didn't want to wake you. *Don't move,* I said. Hold yourself still in the still of this. Wait. Wait. And then I felt it, my whole life, coming back to me, all the images, every event, but like there was finally room in me for them. Like I'd created a womb in myself and something was being born there. All I'd felt, done, suffered, all the violence of my passage through life, was being transmuted into something else. Like I was giving birth to myself. Out of myself. Feeling in myself something I'd never felt before. I wept then, but in a way I never had before. There was no desperation in it. The tears were warm and slow-streaming down my cheeks-and full of what I can only call gladness. But grief too, real grief. A grief for her deeper than any I'd felt before when the panic to deny who I was got all mixed up in it. No, this was real grief. Grief for someone I never knew-someone who never had a chance like mine to know herself. For a life that never was. Unforgivable-to take that from someone. And so for the first time I could really say it to her: " I'm sorry, sorry for your lossfor taking from you the chance to discover who you were." *(breaks down and weeps.)*

The journey. It's all that matters and the only way to make it is to live purely with nothing between you and who you are. For some, it takes all their time here just to get started-but that's enough. A life begun. I was lucky, I always had remorse. I didn't have to waste years trying to crack the hard nut of denial.

I can't say I'm thankful for my life. That would be obscene. And yet I'm one of the fortunate men. I found a way, in this place, to do what few people can do. Rehabilitated? I don't know what that means. After a time any man in here isn't the same man he was when

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he got here. Because there are only two choices. To finish it -- become the thing one was trying to be on the outside. Murder. Rape. Terror. Revenge. Or to somehow find a way to live life to the full every day, knowing it isn't life, can't ever be life. Life is what I took. That's what I try to live too, knowing that every breath I draw comes after she, the woman I killed, Rosalie, Rosalie Romans, drew her last

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